

gives preference to those with share ratios of 1 and over (uploaded as much or more than downloaded)—meaning you get better speeds. This is usually taken care of at the tracker, so when using a private trackers, keep your share ratio in mind, unless you want to get banned from the group. (You usually get to use a private tracker after signing up at a torrent site.)

Ever since BitTorrent became the weapon of choice for P2Pers, the term Share Ratio determines what people think of you. It's actually considered rude to have a share ratio of anything less than 1, and the terms "Leech" and "Hit and run" are used as insults for those with 0.something share ratios.

The Legality

As we mentioned earlier, the BitTorrent network accounts for the majority of Earth's Internet Traffic, and over half of the world's P2P traffic. Unfortunately, the majority of this traffic is illegal downloading of pirated content. Currently, the BT network is most popular for illegal music, movies and software, and pornography accounts for a rather large chunk of the sharing. Often, users think the BT network is anonymous, and that they're safe when downloading pirated content. Nothing

could be further from the truth, because the BT protocol is transparent and it's easy for anyone to see who is uploading and downloading any given torrent—IP addresses of the seeds and peers are plainly visible. If the authorities decide to persecute, it's very easy for them to tell which IPs are illegally downloading copyrighted content, and just as easily to trace the IP to your house.

Private Vs. Public Trackers

A common misconception is that if you want to download something pirated, you should use a private tracker. People think that since private trackers need authentication, and are usually very closed groups that share the latest pirated content, they're safe. Wrong! Anti-piracy organisations could target any group, and honestly, it's not really hard to pretend to be someone else on the Internet. Users of private trackers are generally considered a worse threat by organisations such as the RIAA (Recording Industry Association of America) and MPAA (Motion Picture Association of America), and others. This is because most users in private groups don't just download torrents, but also rip CDs and DVDs and post new torrents as well. Think of it like organised crime, where every

BitTorrent: File Sharing

In the illustration above, User A has the complete file (Pizza), C and D are downloading and B has just joined the swarm. Data being sent from one user to another is depicted as the delivery boys. B is downloading from everyone, A is seeding to everyone and C and D are both uploading to each other and B and downloading from each other and A. All users contact the tracker to inform it of their existence and progress when they start uploading / downloading, and periodically as well to find more users downloading and uploading the same file